

- RAG Learning

2.4 Language Change

AQA A-Level English Language (7702) — Paper 2 Section A

Language Change studies how English has developed over time (from around 1600 to the present day, per the spec). You need to know the **historical periods**, the **mechanisms** (semantic shift, neologisms, grammatical simplification), the **models** (S-curve, wave, random fluctuation, functional), and the **attitudes** (Aitchison, Crystal vs prescriptivists).

Historical Periods of English



2.4.1 Historical Periods

Old English (c. 450 – 1066)

Germanic origins. Complex inflectional system; four grammatical cases; distinctive runic and later Latin-alphabet script. Very different from Modern English — largely unintelligible without study.

Middle English (1066 – c. 1500)

Norman Conquest introduced massive French lexis — law, cuisine, warfare, fashion. Inflections simplified. Chaucer's *Canterbury Tales* (c. 1400) shows a language recognisable but archaic.

Early Modern English (c. 1500 – 1700)

Printing press (Caxton, 1476) accelerated standardisation. The **Great Vowel Shift** (c. 1400–1700) changed the sound of long vowels. Shakespeare and the King James Bible (1611) are Early Modern. Thou/thee/thine coexisted with you/your until they gradually faded. Variable spelling normalised over time.

Modern English (1700 – present)

Johnson's *Dictionary* (1755) consolidated spelling and definitions. Colonisation and empire spread English globally. Industrial Revolution added technical lexis. 20th century: broadcasting, global English, digital media. 21st century: internet-driven lexical change, new Englishes, inclusive forms.

2.4.2 Mechanisms of Change

Semantic change

Type	Description	Example
Broadening	Word acquires wider meaning	"Dog" (once a specific breed) → any canine
Narrowing	Word acquires narrower meaning	"Meat" (once any food) → flesh
Amelioration	Meaning becomes more positive	"Nice" (once "foolish") → pleasant
Pejoration	Meaning becomes more negative	"Silly" (once "blessed") → foolish; "awful" (once "awe-inspiring") → bad
Metaphorical shift	Literal meaning extends figuratively	"Mouse" as computer input device
Weakening	Loss of force	"Awesome" (once in-spiring awe) → casual "very good"

Word-formation processes

Process	Description	Example
Affixation	Adding prefix/suffix	un-+ forget + -able → unforgettable
Compounding	Combining two free morphemes	"laptop", "bookshop"
Blending	Merging parts of two words	"brunch" (breakfast + lunch), "smog" (smoke + fog)
Clipping	Shortening	"exam" from "examination"; "app" from "application"
Acronym / Initialism	Initials of multi-word expressions	"NATO" (pronounced as word), "DIY" (letters)
Eponym	Word from a name	"sandwich" (Earl of Sandwich), "boycott"
Borrowing	Adopting from another language	"tsunami" (Japanese), "karaoke" (Japanese), "barista" (Italian)
Conversion	Changing word class	"text" (noun → verb); "friend" (noun → verb on social media)
Backformation	Removing an affix to create a new word	"edit" from "editor"; "burgle" from "burglar"
Coinage	Entirely new invention	"Kodak", "Google" (as a brand)

Grammatical change

- Loss of thou/thee/thine (completed by c. 1700 for everyday use).
- Expansion of modal verbs' semantic ranges.
- Rise of progressive tense in modern English.

- Re-emergence of singular **they** for gender-neutral reference — attested since the 14th century and now standard.
- Contracted forms ("don't", "won't") moving between registers.

2.4.3 Models of Change

S-curve (Labov)

Changes typically follow an S-shaped diffusion: slow initial uptake among innovators, rapid spread through the community, then plateau as the form approaches universality. Observed in sound change, grammatical change and lexical diffusion.

Wave theory (Bailey)

Innovation begins at an epicentre and spreads outward in waves, weakening with geographical and social distance. Explains why neighbouring regions share features while distant regions retain older forms.

Random fluctuation (Hockett)

Some change arises from unintentional variation, performance errors or chance adoption. Over time, some variants stabilise as new norms. A limitation: cannot explain patterned sociolinguistic variation (e.g. why women and urban speakers often lead change, as Labov found).

Functional theory (Halliday)

Language changes to meet the changing communicative needs of its users. New domains (technology, commerce, politics, identity) produce new lexis and registers. Functional motivation, not decay.

2.4.4 Attitudes to Change — Aitchison vs Prescriptivism

Jean Aitchison's Reith Lectures (1996) critiqued three prescriptivist metaphors for change:

Metaphor	Claim	Aitchison's critique
Damp spoon	Change is caused by laziness	Most sound changes require more, not less, articulatory effort; "laziness" is moralising not linguistic
Crumbling castle	Language was once pure and is decaying	No "golden age" ever existed; English has always been varied and evolving
Infectious disease	Change spreads harmfully	Spread is a sign of social connection and communicative utility, not pathology

Aitchison's position — shared by David Crystal — is descriptivist: change is natural, systematic and often enriching. Complaints about decline reflect social anxiety, not linguistic decline.

2.4.5 Drivers of Change

- **Social contact and migration** — new vocabulary and grammatical features from contact languages.
- **Technology** — digital media producing "googled", "tweet", "swipe", "doomscroll"; new genres (tweet, meme, TikTok).
- **Political and ideological change** — inclusive lexis, shifts in taboo, reclaiming of pejorative terms.
- **Globalisation** — accelerated diffusion of new forms; emergence of pluricentric Englishes.
- **Prestige** — changes spread through socially prestigious groups.
- **Functional pressure** — language adapts to communicative needs.

2.4.6 Recent and Ongoing Change

- **Singular "they"** for any person — historically attested, now widely standard.
- **Uptalk / HRT (high rising terminal)** on declaratives.
- **Like as a quotative marker** — "and I was like..."

- **Zero-derivation verbs** — "text", "friend", "ghost" (verb).
- **Internet lexis** — "swipe", "unfollow", "cancelled", "vibe".
- **Inclusive forms** — "chairperson", "firefighter", gender-neutral pronouns.
- **"Literally" as an intensifier** — a semantic shift with 18th-century precedents, decried by prescriptivists but consistent with historical patterns.

2.4.7 Case Study — Digital Change

The last 25 years show accelerated lexical change tied to digital media. David Crystal's work on "internet linguistics" argues that digital communication is not ruining English but adding new registers. Features:

- New lexis tied to digital practice: "doomscroll", "unfriend", "swipe".
- Graphological innovation: emoji as paralinguistic resource, creative capitalisation, ALL CAPS for shouting.
- Reanalysis of punctuation: the full stop acquiring pragmatic weight in digital chat.
- New genres: tweet, meme, TikTok captions — each with register conventions.

Texters with high phonological awareness often produce creative abbreviations. Research (Crystal, Tagg, Wood) shows digital mode does not replace standard writing ability in educated users — it adds a register.

Applied Example: The verb "to text" is a perfect case study in change. It began as a noun (text = written document). Through conversion, it became a verb (to text = send SMS). It then showed regular morphology in the past tense ("I texted you"). Each step illustrates a different mechanism of change — conversion, then regular inflection — all within two decades. A top-band answer links such contemporary examples to Halliday's functional theory.

2.4.8 How to Analyse Language Change at A-Level

1. Identify the **period** of the text(s).

2. Identify specific **changed features** — lexical, grammatical, graphological.
3. Classify the mechanism (broadening, narrowing, conversion, etc.).
4. Link to **model**: S-curve, wave, random fluctuation, functional.
5. Consider **context**: what social / technological / political drivers explain the change?
6. Evaluate **attitudes**: how might prescriptivists and descriptivists each interpret this?

Exam Tip: Paper 2 often gives a historical text paired with a modern one. Identify change at multiple linguistic levels, always linking features to meaning and function. Use Aitchison's and Crystal's descriptivist framework, but show awareness of prescriptivist views for evaluation. Include DATED examples alongside contemporary ones to demonstrate that change is continuous.

Key Terms Checklist

Make sure you can define and illustrate: **broadening / narrowing / amelioration / pejoration / weakening, affixation, compounding, blending, clipping, acronym, eponym, borrowing, conversion, backformation, neologism, Great Vowel Shift, S-curve, wave theory, functional theory, random fluctuation, standardisation, golden age fallacy**. Theorists / figures: **Aitchison, Crystal, Hockett, Halliday, Labov, Bailey, Johnson (1755), Caxton (1476)**.